

THE NPC JOB

Game Development Hackathon Proposal

Team Members

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Game Overview

The NPC Job is a short 2D comedy-adventure game set in a stereotypical fantasy RPG world. Instead of playing as the legendary hero, the player is an ordinary NPC whose job is to keep the “chosen one” alive and moving toward his quest.

The hero is completely incompetent: he ignores instructions, attacks harmless creatures, steals objects, gets distracted by random items, and regularly creates problems that the player must solve. The player therefore does not directly control the hero, but manipulates the environment around him.

The central mechanic is **Light**. Torches, lamps, mirrors, and other light sources can be activated, moved, or redirected to reveal paths, objects, hazards, enemies, and mechanisms. The player must use these systems to guide the hero through each area.

Initially, the game appears to be a humorous parody of RPG conventions. As the player progresses, subtle inconsistencies begin to appear in NPC dialogue, environmental events, and the hero’s behavior.

At the end, the game rewinds important events and presents them from the perspective of the inhabitants of the world. The player discovers that their interpretation of the “hero” and his actions was incomplete. Events that appeared funny or harmless now have a completely different meaning, producing the central 180-degree twist.

Core Gameplay

The gameplay loop is:

1. Observe the hero and understand what he is attempting to do.
2. Predict or react to his unpredictable behavior.
3. Manipulate the environment using light.
4. Reveal paths, objects, hazards, or mechanisms.
5. Solve environmental puzzles so the hero can continue.
6. Deal with the consequences of the hero’s actions.

Light is a functional gameplay system rather than a visual effect. Example interactions include:

- Lighting hidden paths or safe areas.
- Redirecting light with movable lamps or mirrors.
- Revealing invisible objects or enemies.
- Activating light-sensitive mechanisms.
- Manipulating illuminated and dark regions to change available routes.

The hero’s AI creates comedy directly through gameplay. For example, the player may illuminate an important quest item, only for the hero to ignore it, destroy a nearby barrel, and accidentally solve the puzzle.

Game Flow

Level 1 – Village: Introduces the chosen hero and basic light mechanics while establishing the comedy.

Level 2 – Forest: Introduces hidden paths, hazards, and increasingly unpredictable hero behavior.

Level 3 – Dungeon: Expands the lighting puzzles while planting narrative inconsistencies.

Level 4 – Castle: The hero approaches his objective and the world begins to suggest that something is wrong.

Level 5 – Recontextualization: The hero completes his quest. Instead of ending, the game rewinds key moments and shows them from another perspective, revealing the consequences of the player’s actions and changing the meaning of earlier scenes.

Theme Integration

Theme	Implementation
Comic	The game parodies RPG conventions through an incompetent hero, absurd quests, exaggerated animations, NPC reactions, and unpredictable gameplay situations.
Light	Light is the primary gameplay mechanic. Players control torches, lamps, mirrors, and illuminated areas to reveal paths and objects, activate mechanisms, expose hazards, and guide the hero.
Twist	The game initially presents the player as an NPC helping a heroic protagonist. The final section rewinds major events and shows them from the world's perspective, revealing that the player's original interpretation was fundamentally incomplete. Previous comedic moments are recontextualized.

Judging Criteria Alignment

Theme Interpretation – 20%: All three themes are integrated directly into the game. Comedy comes from the hero and RPG parody, Light forms the main mechanic, and the Twist changes the interpretation of previous gameplay.

Gameplay and Mechanics – 30%: The game is built around observation, autonomous hero behavior, environmental manipulation, and light-based puzzle solving. The player continuously reacts to the hero rather than simply following a linear narrative.

Technical Stability – 20%: The game is intentionally scoped as a small 2D project using reusable environments and mechanics. It will be continuously tested and exported as a browser-playable Godot build for deployment on itch.io.

Audio-Visual Cohesion – 20%: The game will use a colorful, exaggerated fantasy-RPG style with expressive animations and comedic sound effects. During the final sequence, the same locations and events will receive altered visual and audio treatment to reinforce the change in perspective.

Hour 12 Plan Compliance – 10%: By Hour 12, the team will have a playable vertical slice containing:

- Player movement and basic hero AI.
- One functional light-based mechanic.
- One complete environmental puzzle.
- One comedic hero interaction.
- Basic UI and level completion.
- Temporary art and audio.

The remaining time will be used for additional levels, expanded lighting mechanics, art, audio, narrative clues, the final recontextualization sequence, browser testing, and polish.

Technical Scope

The project will be developed in **Godot** as a 2D browser-playable game. Reusable systems will be created for character movement, simple hero AI, light sources, environmental interactions, dialogue, and level transitions.

The target experience is approximately **15–30 minutes**, allowing the team to prioritize polish and reliability within the 100-hour development period.

Player Experience

The intended progression is:

Funny RPG parody → “This hero is an idiot.” → Something feels wrong → Recontextualization → “I misunderstood the entire game.”

The central design principle is that the twist should not merely provide new information. It should **change the meaning of information the player has already experienced**, making Comic, Twist, and Light part of one coherent gameplay experience.